CORE FALSE BELIEF #20 · RULES I LIVE BY

“I must not make mistakes.”

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Where it often comes from

Fear of mistakes often comes from harsh punishment, ridicule, or anger when we got something wrong as children. Some families or schools treated every error as a character flaw. Later, a person may avoid trying new things, procrastinate, redo work endlessly, or hide errors, all to avoid the shame that once came with mistakes.

What Scripture teaches

James writes plainly that we all stumble in many ways. Scripture never pretends God’s people are error-free; it shows Him forgiving, teaching, and restoring them. When we sin, confession brings forgiveness and cleansing. When we simply make honest mistakes, God’s mercies are new every morning. The righteous fall and rise again. In Christ there is no condemnation. Mistakes are part of learning, not proof of failure, and God is patient with us as we grow.

> *“We all stumble in many ways. If anyone is never at fault in what he says, he is a perfect man, able to control his whole body”* (James 3:2).

Also see

> “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:9).

> “For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times” (Proverbs 24:16).

> “Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- Mistakes are unacceptable.
- If I make a mistake, I’ll be humiliated.
- I’d rather not try than get it wrong.
- I go over things again and again to be sure.
- One error can ruin everything.
- I can’t forgive myself for mistakes.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Treating one mistake as total failure.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining terrible consequences from small errors.
- Labeling: Calling myself stupid or useless after a mistake.
- Should statements: Insisting I should never get anything wrong.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that mistakes were unacceptable?
- What actually happened the last time I made a mistake?

- How do I treat other people when they make mistakes?
- What have I learned from past mistakes?
- What does God do with our mistakes and sins?
- What would I try if I weren't afraid of mistakes?

Truth summary

> I will make mistakes, because every person does. Mistakes are part of learning, not proof that I am a failure. God forgives my sins, is patient with my errors, and helps me grow. I can try, learn, and keep going.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Grace
- Confession
- Thinking, Healthy
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Dear Younger Me — MercyMe
Past wounds and choices do not have to become a person's permanent identity.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God's forgiveness addresses lingering guilt and fear of condemnation.

He Touched Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This older favorite celebrates Christ's restoring grace; it is not a promise of immediate physical healing.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must not make mistakes"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must not make mistakes." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me mistakes were unacceptable?
- ☐ What happened the last time I made a mistake?
- ☐ How do I treat others' mistakes?
- ☐ What have I learned from mistakes?
- ☐ What does God do with mistakes and sins?
- ☐ What would I try if I weren't afraid?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ We all stumble in many ways.
- ☐ God forgives and cleanses me.
- ☐ Mistakes are part of learning.
- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ His mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ I can try without fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ James 3:2
  "We all stumble in many ways. If anyone is never at fault in what he says, he is a perfect man, able to control his whole body."
- ☐ 1 John 1:9
  "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Mistakes and lessons: Each day, write one mistake you made and one thing you learned from it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, James 3:2 becomes: "Tom can write: "Everyone stumbles, including me. God is patient with me as I learn.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Make a harmless mistake on purpose. Do something small imperfectly, such as mispronouncing a word or leaving a typo, and notice that nothing terrible happens.
- [ ] Try something new. Attempt one new activity where you are a beginner.
- [ ] Share a mistake. Tell one trusted person about a mistake and how you handled it.
- [ ] Respond like a coach. After a mistake, write what a kind coach would say to you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must not make mistakes": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A mistake I learned from
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must not make mistakes.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I am so afraid of getting things wrong. Thank You that You know we all stumble, and that You forgive and restore. Help me try, learn, and grow without fear, resting in Your patience and grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.